budget. I implemented the zero-based budget approach and used the debt snowball method to pay off my debt. Although I had to slow down midway through my journey to cashflow my wedding, I still remained consistent with making my debt repayments. Ultimately, after getting married, I combined incomes with my husband. Together we downsized even more and put every extra penny toward finishing off my debt repayment. Now after becoming debt-free, our goal is to invest in the stock market and in my own business. Being debt-free enables us to put more money into the market via retirement savings and our own curated portfolio.

Q. How did you adjust your mindset to stay focused during your debt payoff process?

A. It all began with relinquishing the idea that debt was an inevitable part of life. The fact of the matter is that it doesn't have to be. Once I realized that and saw others who could serve as a testament to that end, I knew I could do it. I also had to become more concerned about my future. Where I would spend money on temporal satisfaction and enjoyment, I had to shift my mindset to consider how the decisions that I was making would impact the future me. I didn't want the future me to be living paycheck to paycheck and burdened with debt, so I had to make better decisions in the present.

Q. What are some key factors that allowed you to build a six-figure investment portfolio?

A few things contributed to my building a six-figure portfolio—specifically my 401(k). I began investing in retirement as soon as I started working. Although I didn't know much about investing at the time, I knew that I needed to start putting something away for retirement. When I first began, it was simply enough to get the company match; however, after working a few years I paused my contributions to pay off debt. Because of this, I knew I would have to be a bit more aggressive to make up for the lost time. After paying off my debt, I simply began putting 15% of my income into my retirement savings. This is a general rule of thumb to use to obtain at least one million in retirement savings by age 65. So, although I didn't have a target number in mind for how much I wanted to put away each year, as I received raises and bonuses at work, the amount naturally increased. By being consistent with this, I was able to hit six-figures in retirement savings